The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Getty Images

Qatar's energy minister, Saad al-Kaabi, said that Gulf **oil-and-gas** exporters would be forced to "call force majeure" on energy shipments within "days". His warning follows American efforts to stabilise the market. America said it would issue a 30-day sanctions waiver for Russian oil on ships already bound for **India**. It also waived sanctions indefinitely on the German subsidiary of Rosneft, a Russian oil giant. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, surged above $90 a barrel on Friday, its highest level in two years.

Israel said it struck an underground bunker in **Tehran** used by Iranian officials, near to where Iran's former supreme leader was killed. It is unclear whether anyone was killed. Israel also continued to bomb Lebanon, targeting Hizbullah, a militia backed by Iran. Israel Defence Forces say they have hit over 500 targets in Lebanon so far.

President Donald Trump said he would not negotiate with Iran and demanded its "unconditional surrender". Mr Trump earlier said he should help choose Iran's new supreme leader, adding that the current front-runner Mojtaba Khamenei, the son of the late Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, would be "unacceptable". He also ruled out a ground invasion of Iran, calling it a "waste of time".

Writing for *The Economist*, Spain's prime minister, **Pedro Sánchez**, explains why he opposes the Iran war. He describes it as "a major threat to the rules-based international order". Defending Spain's decision not to let America use its military bases, he says "Real allies owe each other mutual support in times of struggle, but not blind obedience down a reckless path."

BlackRock, the world's largest asset manager, capped withdrawals from its $26bn HPS Corporate Lending Fund as fears of a **private-credit** bust intensified on Wall Street. Shareholders requested redemptions worth roughly $1.2bn, or 9.3%, of the fund's value, but BlackRock limited payouts to around $620m, or 5%, the firm said. BlackRock's shares fell by more than 7% on Friday.

The **unemployment rate** in **America** rose from 4.3% to 4.4% in February as employers cut 92,000 jobs, dampening prospects for the jobs market. The health-care sector, usually a reliable engine of growth, lost 28,000 jobs. The fall was in part driven by a month-long strike by 31,000 workers at Kaiser Permanente, a health-care consortium. Wages remained strong. Average hourly earnings were up 3.8% from a year ago.

Iceland announced that its referendum on resuming discussions to join the **European Union** will be held on August 29th. Polls show the country is split; between 40-50% are in favour of EU membership. The country's initial negotiations with the EU began in 2009 but were shelved in 2015 over fears of the potential loss of control of Iceland's fishing industry.

Figure of the day: 81%, the proportion of students who failed the 50-yard swim test at Williams College between 2013 and 2019 who were students of colour. Read our story about a tradition that has become awkward for America's universities.

Photograph: AP

The Gulf mulls retaliation against Iran

Iranian aerial attacks are rocking the Gulf. Iran has fired more than 1,000 drones and 196 ballistic missiles at the United Arab Emirates; it has also targeted energy infrastructure in Saudi Arabia and Qatar. Even Oman, which days ago was acting as mediator in last-ditch talks between America and Iran, has been hit. Dubai's airport, one of the world's busiest, is closed, save for a handful of repatriation flights. Thousands of travellers are stranded.

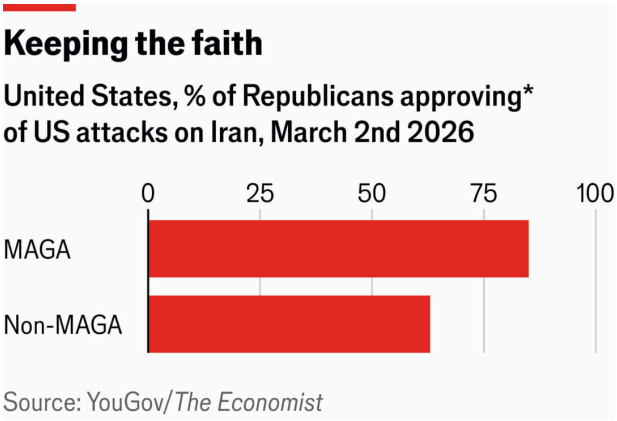
Gulf states are chewing over their response. Anwar Gargash, a senior Emirati official, said military retaliation is "definitely" on the table; Saudi officials suggest the same. That could range from flying joint patrols over the Persian Gulf to launching symbolic strikes on Iran. But joining the war would risk prompting further attacks. The Gulf countries have to consider how long their supplies of missile interceptors can hold out (officials insist they are ample) and how much economic pain they can tolerate.

Photograph: Reuters

MAGA's split over Donald Trump's war

Donald Trump's war on Iran is roiling MAGA media. Some of the president's most ardent cheerleaders have criticised the strikes against Iran as a betrayal of his pledge to end America's "forever wars" and to focus on domestic policy. Tucker Carlson and Megyn Kelley, conservative talk-show hosts, have suggested that Israel forced Mr Trump's decision to go to war, which he denies.

The president also dismisses the notion that such MAGA influencers speak for his political movement. "MAGA is Trump," as he recently put it. He's probably right. Roughly 85% of Americans who identify as "MAGA Republicans" approve of the strikes on Iran, according to a YouGov/*The Economist* poll. Some 63% of non-MAGA Republicans felt the same. For now, at least, the base is still following its leader.



Photograph: Getty Images

America’s volatile jobs data

America’s economy looked to be on an upswing. Economists spent the first half of 2025 fretting about the damage that Donald Trump’s tariff crusade would do, and the second half nervously eyeing the unemployment rate as it crept higher. But the jobs market seemed to be stabilising and growth—buoyed by fiscal stimulus from Mr Trump’s tax giveaways—picking up. The closely watched service-sector purchasing managers’ index gave its strongest reading since 2022 in figures for February.

Still, employment figures released on Friday put pause on any champagne-popping. They showed the economy lost 92,000 jobs in February; economists had expected it to add some 55,000. A big fall in jobs in the healthcare industry in part explained the drop. The figures present a conundrum for the Federal Reserve, which has not looked keen on cutting interest rates again. Fears that Mr Trump’s war on Iran could push up inflation will probably keep the bank cautious, but more weak jobs data might change the calculation.

Photograph: AP

The hitch in Canada’s global trade plan

Mark Carney is meeting Japan’s prime minister, Takaichi Sanae, in Tokyo on Friday. It is the first bilateral visit by a Canadian prime minister in a decade, and follows stops in India and Australia. The aim of Mr Carney’s global tour is to diversify Canada’s trade away from America as President Donald Trump muses about walking away from a free-trade pact between the two countries and Mexico.

Yet Canada’s task is not easy. Japanese business leaders will probably stress the importance of Canada’s link to the American market in their meetings with Mr Carney. The country’s ambassador to Canada recently said that Japanese carmakers would need continued access to America to make new Canadian investments. Those firms made 77% of the 1.2m vehicles built in Canada last year. Mr Trump is applying pressure on the industry, too. He wants American carmakers to leave Canada and set up production lines at home.

Photograph: Warner Bros/LMK

The resurrection of the monster flick

Last year "Frankenstein" was brought back from the dead. Guillermo del Toro's distinctive retelling in film starred a gorgeous monster for the Instagram age. Now "The Bride!", a gothic romance released in cinemas on Friday, repeats the concept. Maggie Gyllenhaal's remake of "Bride of Frankenstein" (1935) imagines that a woman killed by gangsters in Chicago in the 1930s is reanimated to marry Mary Shelley's lonely monster.

The cast is frightfully good—Jessie Buckley is the bride and Christian Bale the monster. But the film is frightfully bad. The story mixes too many genres, from a science-fiction framing to a detective subplot. Bonnie-and-Clyde-style capers spark a women's protest movement. (Shelley also reappears, depicted, unfairly, as a spiteful ghost.) "The Bride!" itself never fully comes to life. Still, that won't stop Hollywood from bringing back more famous creatures: "The Mummy", "The Yeti" and "Clayface" are all to come this year.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Friday: What musical term refers to both an individual song on an album and an isolated channel from a single instrument that is mixed with others to make a recording?

Thursday: What type of footwear, which raised the user's height, was very popular in the 1970s?

Perhaps one has to be very old before one learns how to be amused rather than shocked.

Pearl Buck